Quick to make, this soup transforms everyday ingredients into a splendid light lunch. Frozen peas, with their natural sweetness, make a good match for the fresh mint.

minted pea and ham soup

SERVES 4–6 **PREP** 15 MINS **COOK** 20–25 MINS **FREEZE** UP TO 2 MONTHS
BEFORE CRÈME FRAÎCHE IS ADDED

2 shallots, finely chopped
2 tbsp butter
1 potato, peeled and chopped
1¼ cups hot vegetable stock
1lb (500g) frozen peas, defrosted
2 handfuls of fresh mint leaves, plus 2 tbsp extra for garnishing
5oz (150g) cooked ham, diced
salt and freshly ground black pepper
2–3 tbsp crème fraîche, to serve

1 Cook the shallots in the butter in a pot over low heat for 2–3 minutes until soft. Add the potato and continue cooking, covered, for another 7–10 minutes or until the potato is tender. Pour in the stock and simmer for 10–15 minutes.

2 In a separate pot, boil 1¾ cups water and cook the peas for 2–3 minutes. Add the mint leaves for the last 20 seconds of cooking. Put the peas and mint into a sieve placed over a bowl, reserving the cooking liquid in the bowl. Add the peas and mint to the stock and process the soup using a blender until smooth, pouring in enough cooking liquid from the peas to loosen the consistency. Stir in the diced ham.

3 For the garnish, stretch a sheet of plastic wrap tightly over a dinner plate. Brush with olive oil and press the extra mint leaves onto the surface. Cover with another layer of plastic wrap and cook in the microwave for 2 minutes, until crisp. Reheat the soup, seasoning with salt and pepper to taste. Serve with a dollop of crème fraîche in the center, garnished with the dried mint leaves.